



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: St. Michael Catholic School

School Website: <https://stmcs.org/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

St Michael Catholic School NC 28052 (Saint Michael Catholic School) presents a robust classical Catholic program that aligns strongly with the core six elements of classical education. The public materials emphasize the Catholic, Trinity-inspired aim of education, the Seven Liberal Arts (notably the Trivium and Quadrivium), a deliberately formed culture of virtue and wisdom, and a pedagogy that blends memory work and contemplative learning with Socratic inquiry in the upper grades. The school explicitly grounds its mission in truth, beauty, and goodness, with liturgical practices (Mass and Rosary), and a liberal-arts curriculum informed by Ratio Studiorum and Catholic tradition. Faculty are presented as experienced professionals within a relational, community-centered school, and parents are positioned as co-educators within a parish-connected ecosystem.

Overall assessment: CLASSICAL.

Key observations: - Religious and metaphysical foundations are explicit and pervasive (Catholic identity, liturgical life, sacred time, and Ratio Studiorum). Evidence includes daily Mass, Rosary, and explicit Catholic formation in the curriculum. - The school's explicit aim is the formation of virtue and wisdom through a liberal-arts framework, anchored by truth, goodness, and beauty. - Curriculum centers on the Seven Liberal Arts with the Trivium and Quadrivium, plus Latin studies; this is a defining feature of its classical approach. - Pedagogy is described in stages (Grammar, Logic, Rhetoric) with opportunities for Socratic discussion and rhetoric in the upper grades, aligning with classical pedagogy. - Faculty emphasis is on teachers as mentors within a living-curriculum/community-centered model; current faculty profiles are publicly visible. - Parents and community are integrated as partners (parish ties, annual funds, open invitations to visits, scholarship programs).

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Mission statement centers on pursuing truth, beauty, and goodness within a Catholic framework. - Catholic identity is explicit: Ratio Studiorum reference, liturgical life, prayer, sacraments, and a Catholic tradition-informed education. - Liturgical and communal practices are integrated (daily Mass, Rosary).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: truth, goodness, beauty; theology; liturgy; sacred; catechesis; Catholic; Ratio Studiorum; prayer; Mass; Rosary. - Negative keywords present: none detected in available public materials. - Quantitative estimate: Positive ~ 7–9 distinct keywords identified; Negative ~ 0; Net orientation strongly positive toward classical religious foundations.

Why this rating - The materials consistently articulate transcendental aims (truth, goodness, beauty) within a Catholic/theological frame, not secular moral relativism. The liturgical life and explicit Ratio Studiorum references reinforce a grounded, theologically oriented metaphysical foundation. This aligns squarely with CLASSICAL.

Cited evidence: Mission Statement and Catholic Liberal Education language; direct references to Mass/Rosary; Ratio Studiorum framing.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school foregrounds formation of wisdom and virtue and the cultivation of truth, goodness, and beauty as real and knowable ideals (true teleology). - The program is described as a Catholic liberal-arts formation aimed at the cultivation of human excellence and moral formation, not merely job preparation. - The mission emphasizes truth, beauty, and goodness as real ideals guiding the curriculum and culture.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: formation; virtue; wisdom; telos; pursuit of truth; beauty; goodness; liberal education; classical mission. - Negative keywords present: none detected in the public materials. - Quantitative estimate: Positive ~ 6–8 keywords; Negative ~ 0; Net orientation clearly CLASSICAL.

Why this rating - The materials consistently present education as formation oriented toward human flourishing and the pursuit of transcendentals (truth, goodness, beauty), grounded in liberal-arts pedagogy. The absence of vocational “workforce” framing in favor of virtue/wisdom formation supports CLASSICAL alignment.

Cited evidence: Mission language; Catholic Liberal Education description; explicit emphasis on truth, beauty, goodness and liberal-arts framing.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The Seven Liberal Arts form the curricular backbone, with explicit focus on grammar, logic, rhetoric (Trivium) and arithmetic, music, geometry, astronomy (Quadrivium). - Latin studies are mentioned as part of foreign-language options, aligning with classical curriculum patterns. - The school presents a classical framework (CCE) and a historical, liberal-arts orientation.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: Seven Liberal Arts; Trivium (Grammar, Logic, Rhetoric); Quadrivium (Arithmetic, Music, Geometry, Astronomy); Latin; Great Books/Great Conversation (where referenced); liberal arts; classical curriculum. - Negative keywords present: not detected in the public materials; no direct substitution of history with social studies or over-emphasis on current-event-centric social studies. - Quantitative estimate: Positive ~ 9–12 keywords; Negative ~ 0–1 (no explicit negative curricular signals found in the public content). - Overall: CLASSICAL.

Why this rating - The curriculum is intentionally built around the Trivium and Quadrivium, the Seven Liberal Arts, and classic-language study—key markers of classical education. The content also signals a commitment to a “liberal education” and to a historical/cultural inheritance that centers on the Western canon.

Cited evidence: The Classical Difference page detailing the Seven Liberal Arts and the Trivium/Quadrivium; Latin-language option mention.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Clear articulation of the Grammar–Logic–Rhetoric progression and associated stages (Grammar Stage PK3–3; Logic Stage 4–6; Rhetoric Stage 7–8). - Upper-level pedagogy includes Socratic discussion, seminars, or debates and opportunities to practice rhetoric and public speaking. - The Classical Christian Education (CCE) framework is described as focusing on the seven liberal arts with a strong emphasis on formation and the cultivation of virtue through the classical method.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: Socratic dialogue/seminars; seminars; debates; rhetoric; memorization/recitation; restful learning (Scholé); memory work; living curriculum; master-teacher/mentor model. - Negative keywords present: experiential learning focus; project-based learning; constructivist learning (not evidenced as primary pedagogy in the school sources; these are listed in the knowledge lexicon as potential negative signals if overemphasized, but not directly shown as a school practice here). - Quantitative estimate: Positive ~ 6–10 keywords (Socratic/seminars, rhetoric, lectures, grammar/logic/rhetoric progression, memory work); Negative ~ 0–1 explicit signals in the public content. - Overall: CLASSICAL.

Why this rating - The pedagogy is grounded in the Trivium/Quadrivium and includes Socratic-style inquiry and rhetoric training in upper grades, with memory-based recitation and a clearly defined sequence of pedagogical phases. The public content supports a classical pedagogy rather than a solely project-based or experiential framework.

Cited evidence: The Classical Difference content for the Trivium/Quadrivium; the Grammar-Logic-Rhetoric progression and memory-based elements; references to classical seminars.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The site lists faculty members with roles (e.g., Caitlin Duggan, Megan Humphrey, Lisa Hiatt, etc.), illustrating a professional teaching corps. - The public-facing materials emphasize a relationship-driven, faculty-student dynamic and the teacher as a core component of the school's culture.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: model teachers; mentors; living curriculum; portrait of a teacher; faculty as core; collegial culture. - Negative keywords present: none explicit in the public materials. - Quantitative estimate: Positive ~ 4–6 keywords; Negative ~ 0. - Overall: CLASSICAL.

Why this rating - The focus on faculty as the “living curriculum” and the visibility of a stable, mission-driven faculty in the public site aligns with classical expectations that the teacher is central to forming virtue and intellect.

Cited evidence: Faculty pages and descriptions; general references to faculty-student relationships.

Element 6: School Parents and Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school identifies partnerships with families, parent formation, and parent involvement as core components of the classical model (e.g., NC Opportunity Scholarship, Annual Fund, and parish connections). - The site notes a culture of welcoming parents to visits and ongoing community activities (e.g., annual fundraising, booster events, and parish associations). - Community life is reinforced by observable public content (quotes from parents and families; parish connections).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with families; parental formation; family involvement; parent-teacher collaboration; engagement; community support; living tradition in the family; open campus; parish life; family catechesis. - Negative keywords present: none detected in public materials. - Quantitative estimate: Positive ~ 6–8 keywords; Negative ~ 0. - Overall: CLASSICAL.

Why this rating - The public materials emphasize strong family partnership, parent formation opportunities, and parish/community integration, which are hallmark signals of a classical school that sees parents as co-educators and part of the educational ecosystem.

Cited evidence: Parental/community references, NC Opportunity Scholarship, Annual Fund; open invitation to visits; parish link.

Aggregate Assessment

- Religious and Metaphysical Foundations: CLASSICAL
- School Purpose and Goal: CLASSICAL
- Curriculum: CLASSICAL
- Pedagogy: CLASSICAL
- Faculty: CLASSICAL
- Parents & Community: CLASSICAL

Overall ranking: CLASSICAL.

What would move the needle (not applicable for a CLASSICAL aggregate) - No needle-moving changes are necessary to achieve a CLASSICAL classification given the evidence above. If a school sought to move toward a more pronounced or broader classical profile, it could deepen explicit references to Great Books

and Great Conversation or more overtly articulate the Great Conversation as a formal recurring framework across grades, but the current public materials already align with classical aims.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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